FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

When missiles stopped flying between the US-Israel and Iran last June, INDIA TODAY called it an 'Uneasy Truce' on its cover and predicted that hostilities would return. The Twelve-Day War did not resolve the questions that sparked it. On the surface, these related to Iran's presumed proximity to developing a nuclear weapon. In less charitable readings, it was a blatant play for power and dominance over the Middle East. That guaranteed a second coming of war. It came on February 28, after tense weeks marked by massive American military movement as well as last-minute negotiations. Just as dialogue seemed on the verge of bearing fruit, peace was shattered by an attack on Tehran. Among those who lay assassinated was Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the 86-year-old Supreme Leader. Since 1989, after Khomeini, he had filled out a unique theocratic role extending to all aspects of political authority, steering Iran's destiny in powerful, controversial ways. He was also among the most important spiritual authorities in Shia Islam globally. With his killing, a conflict rooted in strategic calculations acquired unmistakable religious overtones.

Three questions immediately arise: How long will the war last? What are its objectives? What will it mean for India? None of them lend themselves to easy answers. We can only attempt to map the uncertainties and possibilities that define the moment.



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Duration first. The mercurial US president Donald Trump wanted a quick 'in and out' strike like in Venezuela, where taking Nicolas Maduro hostage yielded a non-conflict that lasted 150 minutes. Early projections suggested that removing the Iranian leadership might be sufficient for the whole system to crumble and that the disaffected citizens of the country would do the rest. That assumption was naive and underestimated the resilience of the Iranian state. Iran was strategically prepared for precisely such a moment. Atop its complex state apparatus, Khamenei had stacked high levels of redundancy: four tiers of succession for religious, military and political helmsmen. You take out one, another comes in. The expectation of a swift collapse proved totally misplaced.

The West's strategic objectives were clear enough. For over two years, Trump's collaborator, Israel's prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu, acting alone or in concert, had gone for vital nodes of Iran's Axis of Resistance one by one, with varying degrees of success: Hamas first, then Hezbollah in Lebanon, then Syria. Their final goal was always to destabilise or tame Iran. They found an opportunity when the Iranian economy went into free fall under the weight of renewed sanctions and triggered nationwide protests in December-January. The state had soon quelled it with an iron hand. So, 'cutting the head of the snake' didn't produce popular revolt. Instead, Iran initiated a prolonged war of attrition, one with a dramatically expanded theatre. Besides Israel and US bases, it's targeting the oil-rich Gulf nations and choking the Strait of Hormuz. That narrow waterway carries 20 per cent of the world's oil supplies, so the disruption reverberates far and wide. "We have kicked over a hornet's nest," says Stephanie T. Williams, senior fellow at Washington-based Brookings Institution, invoking "the law of unintended consequences." America and Israel hope to crush Iran's military capability, to render it unable to pursue the war any further. The question no one is really sure of is the extent of Iran's missile stockpile.

The war's objectives are no less contested. America frames the conflict as a necessary step to prevent a nuclear-armed Iran. Critics argue that the spectre of an imminent Iranian bomb has been invoked for decades without definitive proof. Then the objective was changed to 'regime change'. The real reason seems to be geostrategic. Central to global energy flows and financial systems, control over the Middle East's strategic geography carries enormous consequences for the emerging world order. Do not discount Israel's ambition to become the regional hegemon once Iran is done. Leaders perhaps also possibly mask personal reasons for declaring war. For Trump, it serves as a WMD (Weapon of Mass Distraction) from the Epstein files; similarly, Netanyahu faces corruption charges and an election later this year. The conflict also intersects with the ambitions of other powers. Iran forms a key link in the evolving strategic alignment between Russia and China. A weakened Iran could complicate Russia's southern security environment and threaten China's energy lifeline. Both powers, therefore, are watching the conflict closely.

For India, the consequences are immediate and complex. It maintains working relationships with all the principal actors. The diplomatic balance will now be tested. West Asia supplies nearly 60 per cent of India's crude oil and natural gas requirements. Any prolonged disruption to energy flows would place significant strain on the economy. India has already been forced to reconsider options it had recently moved away from, including purchases from Russia. There is also a human dimension. In the last financial year, remittances from the Gulf reached an extraordinary $51.5 billion, close to 1.5 per cent of India's GDP. Behind that figure stands a diaspora of 10 million Indians living and working across the region. As the conflict expands with the threat of drone attacks on cities, their security and livelihoods become a matter of urgent concern. The stakes, therefore, extend far beyond the battlefield. In our cover story, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa, who covered the 1989 Khomeini-Khamenei transition on the ground, now examines the conflict in depth, analysing its geopolitical drivers and possible trajectories. Whatever course this war takes, it will resonate far beyond the region.

For now, the world watches anxiously as one of India's oldest civilisational neighbours confronts a grave crisis that probably will be transformative.

(Aroon Purie)